Release Governance & Test Strategy

Traceability, coverage, defect policy, execution evidence and release decisioning

Document status: CURRENT unless otherwise identified | Enterprise delivery assurance training corpus

1. Governance Objective

Northstar Commerce is preparing a multi-release modernization of its digital commerce platform. This specification is intentionally detailed and includes overlapping business, API, testing, and governance content so that delivery-assurance systems must reason across multiple artifacts rather than rely on one isolated paragraph.

Release governance connects approved scope to evidence. A release decision should be explainable in terms of requirement coverage, execution results, unresolved defects, known risk, and explicit approvals or waivers.

1.1 Operational Guidance

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2. Traceability Expectations

Every release-blocking requirement should have at least one active verification path. Traceability may connect requirement to acceptance criterion, test case, execution result, and defect evidence.

Links should remain stable when test cases are revised; obsolete tests should not silently count as active coverage.

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3. Delivery Assurance Workflow

Requirements must be sufficiently clear before acceptance criteria and test oracles are finalized. The workflow diagram below is part of the normative guidance.

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3.3 Delivery Assurance Workflow

Figure: requirement-to-evidence delivery assurance sequence. The visual is an authoritative part of this document and should remain retrievable during ingestion.

The workflow expresses ordering and dependency: requirements are clarified before acceptance criteria are finalized; traceability links requirements to test evidence; execution results and unresolved defects inform the release decision. A system that extracts only nearby paragraphs may lose this sequence.

4. Coverage and Quality Gates

P0 and P1 requirements without active tests require explicit review. Open S1 defects are release blocking. Open S2 defects normally block release unless a documented risk acceptance exists.

Coverage percentage alone is insufficient; teams should consider requirement priority, test type, recent execution result, and unresolved defect severity.

Risk	Expected Control	Release Impact
P0 requirement has no active test	Coverage gap must be reviewed	Blocks release unless formally waived
Current and archived requirement conflict	Current approved version wins	Requires source/version evidence
Failed S1/S2 defect remains open	Release risk review required	Normally blocking
Requirement is ambiguous	Clarification required before oracle	Test generation should not invent rule

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5. AI-Assisted Test Generation

AI-generated tests are proposals until validated against approved requirements and observable system behavior. Generated cases should include positive, negative, boundary, failure-recovery, and security scenarios where applicable.

The system should identify ambiguity rather than invent business policy.

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6. Execution and Evidence

Automated execution results should record test case, environment, build, timestamp, outcome, duration, and evidence location. Reruns should not erase the original failure history.

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7. Release Readiness Decision

A release-readiness summary should distinguish covered, uncovered, failing, blocked, waived, and ambiguous requirements. Human release accountability remains explicit even where AI assists analysis.

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